

Some technology access is always going to be more beneficial than none, even if it's a limited experience. Consider the experiment run by the One Laptop Per Child (OLPC) organisation in remote Ethiopian villages. They simply dropped tablets containing e-books, movies, cartoons, paintings, and other content (but no internet access) without any prior training other than how to charge the devices. Within a few months the kids in those villages not only figured out how to consume the content, but even went so far as to customise their Android look and feel (<http://dgit.in/frb3c33>). Today, they're ready to start consuming more content, and dare we say, hungry for more. I'll come back to this point towards the end of this article, but for now, let's look at the arguments against Free Basics.

IT'S AGAINST NET NEUTRALITY!

Ah the open and free level playing field that is the internet. A sublime utopia where all data is treated equally, where young upstarts armed with an idea can (in theory) overthrow established corporations, and yes, that young upstart could be you... But guess what? The internet isn't neutral and it's never been. Since I'm working with a limited amount of space to present my case, I'll let Robert's column (page O6) explain how. If you haven't read it already I'd urge you to do so and then come back.

Even if you are a purist, consider the reality that the now abhorred term Zero Rating doesn't mean that certain data streams are being given preferential treatment, it only means that certain data won't be charged. Savetheinternet.in, the advocacy group that's been doing a good job of keeping a lookout to protect the rights of indian netizens, often cites Gigato as a viable solution to address this problem of getting the underprivileged masses on to the internet. The popular belief is that unlike Free Basics, Gigato doesn't violate net neutrality norms. Instead of not charging for certain types of data, Gigato actually refunds data that is consumed while connecting to their partner clients. Even if it doesn't technically violate the (loosely defined) principles of net neutrality, at the very least the practice is anti-competitive because only those clients with already deep pockets can afford to pay for their user's data.

This breaks down the utopian "level-playing field" dream that we're supposedly trying to protect.

What's funny is that when a violation of net neutrality norms serves our interests, we don't seem to care as much. Your ISP has a tie up with YouTube for local caching? This means that you don't have to wait for ages for videos to buffer, and you love the experience. Unless you're a YouTube competitor that is. Where are all the internet petitions against that? In some cases, ISPs don't even count YouTube data against your FUP limit! If torrents were Zero Rated, would you honestly be up in arms to protest it?

CARVING UP THE INTERNET

We've all seen the forwards. ₹50 for a WhatsApp pack, another ₹10 for the Facebook pack... Yes, this is a very valid risk.



However, like most other sectors in India, this one is regulated as well. We have a very competent regulatory authority that has shown some remarkable aptitude recently, when it penalised Facebook for its methods by calling them a "crude and orchestrated opinion poll". Why such little faith in the TRAI? I'm quite happy with the way the TRAI is being inclusive (at least ostensibly) and following what looks like a well thought out process.

Think about it, maybe a well policed and government regulated Free Basics could actually end up as something beneficial to all. Or example, let's assume the TRAI puts in a regulation directing all telcos to always make available to everyone an "all access" internet pack. Such a pack shall never be priced higher

than the price of 5 individual packs, and will never have differential data speeds. Plus, to preempt another criticism, let's say that these options are only available to users who have been online with an all access pack for, say, three months. After that, let telcos have a field day coming up with whatever WhatsApp, and Viber and Flipkart packs they want to. If some people genuinely just want connectivity to social networking platforms when on the go, let them pay less and get that selective service.

Also, let's face it, this whole debate isn't really about whether Ganesh the farmer is going to benefit from Free Basics' weather updates... it's really about how we feel that a dangerous precedent will be set. You are afraid that if a restricted form of the internet is allowed to operate, who knows, one day there might be restrictions imposed on your porn and torrents. Let's say an ISP says, "you know what, we will offer you a pack that doesn't include porn or torrents for half the price." Your dad will say wonderful and subscribe to it. How do you explain that you need both those? Or maybe it's not ISP driven. Maybe it's an overzealous government imposing some sanskari beliefs. If Free Basics is accepted, maybe that will get accepted too. Maybe people won't come down to the streets in protest.

The point is firstly let's drop the pretence that we care about the "quality" or "nature" of the internet that farmer Ganesh is getting. We're more bothered about the larger fallout that could (with great leaps of an overactive imagination) someday affect us. Is that reason enough to deny Ganesh some form of access right now? I say let's fight those imaginary demons when they manifest themselves. Not now.

EVERYONE DESERVES THE FULL, UNRESTRICTED INTERNET

We couldn't agree more. If you read Zucky's impassioned opinion pieces you'd probably see that beyond all the spiel, our seemingly do gooding billionaire is genuinely confused about the backlash he's facing. In some foreign media coverage about this topic, I came across this very interesting line: The very people Free Basics was supposed to please seem to be its biggest detractors. The trouble is that the people who Free Basics was supposed